A PANDEMIC PICTURE

Rima Das's new film takes stock of what we lost in Covid's brutal second wave





Jaan (Abhijit Das), the protagonist of Rima Das's latest directorial feature *Tora's Husband*, has a lot on his mind. The sole proprietor of a bakery-cum-restaurant in Assam, he sees his business bleed money during the pandemic. As he tries his best to retain all his employees, he also takes up a contract for some construction work. On the home front, his pet dog, Piku, has been missing for almost a week. As Jaan complains of headaches, one can see why the character could be a stand-in for director Rima Das, who again had a lot on her plate—not only did she shoot and edit her film, she has also been credited for its production design.

As the first Indian film to premiere in the 'Platform' section of the 47th Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF), *Tora's Husband* is also Das's third consecutive film to premiere at TIFF. Over time, has filmmaking become easier for Das? "I think it's always hard. If you look at *Village Rockstars* (2017)," says Das, "the set-up is very different from *Tora's Husband*." What does make things easier, she adds, is her ability to shoot more economically, since she can envision the scenes on an edit table. "I think I have better instincts now."

The film focuses on how financial strife affects interpersonal relationships in a family

Shot over a period of nearly two years, Das's film focuses on how financial strife affects the interpersonal relationships of a family. It's a rare film that delves into the horrific second wave of Covid-19 infections that hit India in April-May, 2021. Das is surprised that more films haven't tackled it. "Maybe it's too soon, and maybe everyone is just processing what happened," says Das. But, she adds, a pandemic film needn't necessarily be only about death tolls and crematoriums: "I'm sure people will look back in 10 years or so. Just like the World War II films we keep seeing in Hollywood, every other year."

Das is also a vital stakeholder in a film movement emerging out of the Northeast, featuring filmmakers such as Bhaskar Hazarika, Kenny Basumatary, Nicholas Kharkhongor, Pradip Kurbah and Wanphrang Diendgoh. What does she feel is the next step for this movement? "I'm just trying to work on the next thing," says Das, "but the way more people are making movies, even though most of them are not even close to recovering their investment, is heartening to see."

Both *Village Rockstars* and *Bulbul Can Sing* (2018) are streaming on Netflix. Does Das ever fear her films getting lost in the deluge of content on such services? "Where I hail from, I don't think I have any complaints about Netflix picking up my films. But yes, we have to rely on the curiosity of audience members, who might take a chance on our films," says Das. ■

Tatsam Mukherjee

HOME TRUTHS

DOCUMENTARIES THAT WON BIG IN TORONTO



TO KILL A TIGER

Best Canadian Feature (TIFF)

Harrowing and inspiring in equal measure, Nisha Pahuja's documentary tells the story of how Ranjit, a farmer in Jharkhand, fights for his daughter after she is gang-raped by three men.



WHILE WE WATCHED

Amplify Voices Award (TIFF)

This documentary follows broadcast journalist Ravish Kumar as he tries to sift truth from untruth, and information from disinformation. Director Vinay Shukla has called this his "love letter to journalism".



GAURI

Best Human Rights Film

Directed by Gauri Lankesh's sister, Kavitha, this documentary investigates the many threats that Indian journalists face. The film was a key highlight of the recently held Toronto Women's Film Festival 2022.